Northwind Retail Group

HR Company Policy Handbook — Effective January 1, 2026 (fictional, for demo purposes only)

1. Working Hours and Attendance

Standard working hours at Northwind Retail Group are 9:00 AM to 5:30 PM, Monday through Friday, with a 30-minute unpaid lunch break. Employees are expected to log their attendance through the company time-tracking portal by 9:15 AM each working day. Flexible start times between 8:00 AM and 10:00 AM are permitted with prior manager approval, provided the employee completes a full 8-hour workday. Persistent unexplained lateness of more than 15 minutes on three or more occasions within a rolling 30-day period will trigger an informal conversation with the employee's manager, followed by a formal attendance improvement plan if the pattern continues.

2. Annual Leave and Time Off

Full-time employees accrue 18 days of paid annual leave per calendar year, credited at a rate of 1.5 days per completed month of service. Unused annual leave may be carried over into the next calendar year up to a maximum of 5 days; any balance beyond that is forfeited on December 31st. Leave requests must be submitted through the HR portal at least 5 working days in advance for requests of 3 days or fewer, and at least 15 working days in advance for requests longer than 3 days. In addition to annual leave, employees are entitled to 10 paid sick days per year and 5 days of paid bereavement leave for the death of an immediate family member. New parents are eligible for 16 weeks of paid parental leave, which may be taken continuously or split into two blocks within the first 12 months following the birth or adoption of a child.

3. Code of Conduct

All employees are expected to treat colleagues, customers, and vendors with respect and professionalism at all times. Harassment, discrimination, or retaliation of any kind is strictly prohibited and will result in disciplinary action up to and including immediate termination. Employees must avoid conflicts of interest and disclose to their manager any outside business activity, financial interest, or personal relationship that could reasonably be seen to influence their judgment at work. Confidential company information, including customer data, unreleased product plans, and internal financial figures, must never be shared outside the company without written authorization from a director-level employee or above.

4. Remote and Hybrid Work

Employees in eligible roles may work remotely up to 3 days per week, with a minimum of 2 days per week spent at their assigned office location to support in-person collaboration. Remote work

arrangements must be agreed upon with the employee's direct manager and documented in the HR system. Employees working remotely are expected to be reachable during core collaboration hours of 10:00 AM to 4:00 PM local time and must join scheduled meetings with video enabled unless a connectivity issue prevents it. The company provides a one-time home-office stipend of $500 for new hybrid employees to cover the cost of a monitor, chair, or similar equipment.

5. Expense Reimbursement

Business-related expenses such as client meals, travel, and approved training courses are reimbursable provided a valid receipt is submitted through the expense portal within 30 days of the purchase. Meal expenses while traveling on company business are capped at $60 per day. Airfare must be booked in economy class for flights under 6 hours; business class is permitted for flights over 6 hours with prior manager approval. Reimbursement requests submitted more than 60 days after the expense date will not be honored except in cases of documented extenuating circumstances approved by HR.

6. Termination and Resignation

Employees wishing to resign are asked to provide a minimum of 2 weeks' written notice for individual-contributor roles and 4 weeks' written notice for management roles, submitted to their manager and HR. During the notice period, the company may, at its discretion, ask the employee to continue working, transition to garden leave, or a combination of both, while continuing to pay the employee's regular salary through the end of the notice period. In cases of termination for cause, including gross misconduct, employment may end immediately without notice or pay in lieu of notice. For all other involuntary terminations, the company provides severance pay of one week's salary per completed year of service, with a minimum of 2 weeks and a maximum of 12 weeks.